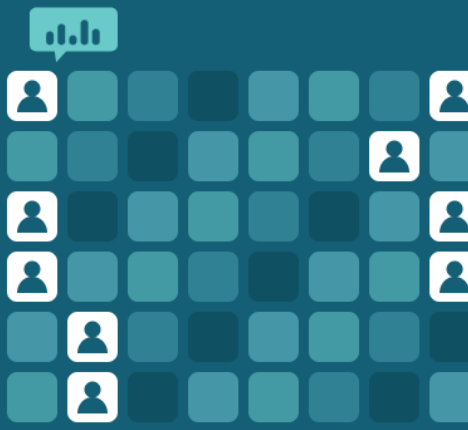
Place-based data training

Activities workbook

Module 3.1: Deeper understanding of context



This training brings together practical guidance for using data in place-based work. It draws on PLACE and Seer Data's work alongside place-based initiatives across Australia.

The training covers the journey many place-based initiatives go on – from finding and accessing data to sharing it, making sense of it with community and using it to support local decisions and action.

Who is it for?

It is designed for people working in or supporting place-based initiatives. You might be new to working with data or already using and managing data as part of your everyday rhythm.

How to use this workbook

Throughout the training, you'll find opportunities to reflect on your work and consider how the ideas and tools apply in your place or initiative. This workbook brings together the activities for this module.

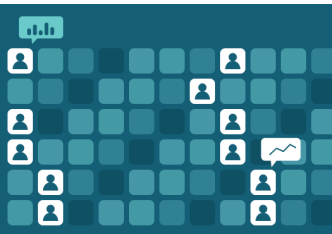
You can work through the training from beginning to end, or choose the modules most relevant to your role, experience and current work. We recommend starting with Welcome to place-based data training. You can return to other sections as you need them.

You can also connect with others doing the training to ask questions, share what you're learning and learn from their experience on PLACExCHANGE at **pxc.placeaustralia.org**.

A collaboration between

PLACE
Partnerships for Local Action & Community Empowerment

Seer
Data & Analytics



Understanding & using data together

Module

3.1 Deeper understanding of context

Section 1	Backbone teams	2 activities
Section 2	Governance, Terms of Reference, and data governance	2 activities
Section 3	Inclusive governance, networks, and community ecosystems	2 activities

Try this now: name the group, and who coordinates it

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Pick one group, initiative or partnership you are part of or work alongside. This is the group you will use for the rest of the module, so choose one you know well enough to answer questions about.

If you are not working with a group at the moment, use one you have worked with before, or one you are trying to get started.

Fill in the table below. In the last column, name one specific thing that would stop happening, not a general worry: the quarterly report nobody else knows how to pull together, the relationship with the local health service, the shared calendar.

The group or initiative I am thinking about	Who holds the coordination work together now (person, role or organisation)	Is that a named and resourced role, or does it happen on top of other work	One thing that would stop if that person stepped away

> Keep this table. Everything else you fill in over the next three sections is about this group.

Try this now: check who carries each function

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Stay with the group you named above. For each of the three functions, write down who carries it at the moment, whether it is resourced, and one thing community data work could add.

If a row has no answer in the second column, that is the finding: you have located a function that is running on nobody.

“Resourced” here means more than money. Note whether there is paid time, cultural labour that is recognised and paid for, meeting space, or data access attached to the function.

The function	Who carries it now	Is it resourced, and how	What community data work could add here
Identifying and securing funding and resources			
Convening stakeholders, community champions and volunteers			
Facilitating agreement on shared purpose and ways of working			

> Look down the second column. A function with no name against it is the first thing to raise at your next meeting, and it is usually easier to raise as a question about the function than as a question about a person.

Try this now: check what your Terms of Reference covers

Apply Apply to your place 1

Stay with the group you named in Section 1. Work through the five things a Terms of Reference sets out, and mark honestly what yours says about each. “We have no Terms of Reference” is a legitimate answer and a useful finding.

In the last column, name the person or group who would need to agree any change to that line. That column is often the more revealing one, because it shows where authority actually sits.

What a Terms of Reference sets out	Does ours say this? (yes, partly, no, or we have no ToR)	Who would need to agree the wording
Purpose and scope of the group		
Roles and responsibilities, and where authority sits		
How decisions are made, and which ones need broader community input		
How community perspectives, lived experience and cultural authority are represented		
How disagreement, tension or conflict is addressed		

> Every “partly”, “no” or blank in the middle column is an item for your governance stocktake. You will add data to this list in the second exercise.

Try this now: draft the data lines for your Terms of Reference

Apply | Apply to your place 2

A strong Terms of Reference includes a clear section on data governance. The six rows below are what that section covers. For each one, write your group's current position in a single line, as it stands today rather than as you would like it to be, then name who would need to agree it.

You are drafting, not finalising. A line that reads "we have not discussed this" is a useful entry, because it turns an assumption into an agenda item.

What the Terms of Reference needs to say about data	Our position in one line	Who needs to agree this
Community ownership and control of data		
Decision-making authority over data use		
Consent and cultural protocols		
Data sharing and access arrangements		
Use of data for learning, accountability, shared measurement, evaluation and advocacy		
How and when data governance gets reviewed		

> Writing these down is what makes data governance visible, deliberate and enforceable. Put this table beside the Terms of Reference gap check from the first exercise: together they are the governance half of your stocktake, and they are specific enough to take to a meeting.

Try this now: who is shaping the decisions, and who is not

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Stay with the group from Sections 1 and 2. Fill in the table for two people or groups who are affected by the group's decisions but are not shaping them. Be specific about who, rather than writing a category.

In the third column, name what is actually keeping them out: the meeting time, the cost of getting there, the language the papers are written in, the fact that the last engagement went badly. In the fourth, name one change you could put to the group at its next meeting, not a full redesign.

Who is shaping decisions now	Who is affected but not here	What is keeping them out	One change I could propose

> Two rows is enough to start. If the third column keeps coming back to the same barrier, you have found something structural rather than personal, and that is a stronger thing to raise.

Try this now: one gap, one connection, one element

Apply Apply to your place 2

Look back at the two rows you filled in earlier, and at the backbone functions with no owner from Section 1. Pick one gap. Name which kind it is, using the three types above, then work out the connection that would help close it and which of the 12 Elements it would strengthen.

Naming the element is what turns a useful introduction into something you can explain to a governance group and a funder.

The last column is the one that makes this real: who has the first conversation, and roughly when.

The gap	Participation, capability or influence?	The connection that would help close it	Which of the 12 Elements it strengthens	Who has the first conversation, and when

> One connection, deliberately chosen and explained, tends to do more than five made because they were available. If the third column names an organisation rather than a person, find the person: relationships are held by people.